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ACADEMY

CREATIVE COURSE · STUDENT RESOURCE

YOUR BRAND IN 7 DAYS

A professional visual identity, no agency needed

BEFORE YOU START

Let's be honest: we all judge a book by its cover. And right now, your potential customers are judging your shop by its cover: your Instagram page, your logo, your product photos, your ads.

According to a frequently cited study, a fraction of a second (around 0.05 seconds) may be all it takes for a visitor to form a first impression of a website. That impression weighs heavily when they decide whether you look credible enough to buy from.

If your visual identity looks messy or amateur, customers assume your products are too. Even if your perfumes are authentic, your cosmetics are flawless and your clothes are better finished than your competitors'.

This guide is here to fix that.

Over the next 7 days, you'll follow a simple, step-by-step system to look like a pro without hiring an expensive agency or needing a design degree.

Here is your roadmap:

- **Day 1:** close the "Trust Gap".
- **Day 2:** define your brand's personality (before you pick a single colour).
- **Day 3:** create a mood board that actually works.
- **Day 4:** a simple system for your colours and fonts.
- **Day 5:** create a professional wordmark and a consistent visual style.
- **Day 6:** build your "Brand Bible" and save hours of work.
- **Day 7:** the secret to staying consistent as you grow.

> **How to use this guide**
>
> One day = one short lesson + one concrete action. Don't read it all in one sitting: complete each day's action before moving on to the next. Your brand takes shape as you put it into practice.

DAY 1 — CLOSE THE TRUST GAP

Imagine this.

You need surgery. You're sitting in the consultation room, nervous. The door opens, and the surgeon walks in wearing... stained sweatpants and an old t-shirt.

Technically, their outfit has nothing to do with their ability to hold a scalpel. They might be the best surgeon in the country. But would you trust them with your life?

Probably not. You'd likely head for the exit.

This is exactly what happens online every day. Humans are visual creatures: we judge a brand's credibility in the blink of an eye. If your page, your ad creatives or your invoices look messy, people subconsciously assume your work is messy, too.

We call this the **Trust Gap**.

The high cost of looking "amateur"

The Trust Gap appears when the quality of your work is a 10/10, but your visual identity is a 4/10. Because customers can't judge the real quality of your products yet, they judge you on the 4/10 they can see.

This inconsistency is expensive. It leads to:

- **Lower pricing power:** it's hard to charge premium prices when you look "budget".
- **Hesitation:** potential customers hold back because something "feels off", without being able to say what.
- **Lost orders:** sloppy design is one of the first reasons people mistrust a website or a page. And a suspicious visitor doesn't place an order.

The good news? You don't need an art degree to fix this. You just need a system that signals "Pro" instead of "Amateur".

Your first quick win

Before you build your new identity, you need to see clearly where the gaps are right now.

> **Your action for today: the 5-minute audit**
>
> - Open your online shop or your Instagram page in one tab.
> - In another tab, open your latest ad creative, your latest invoice or a photo of your product label.
> - Look at them side by side.
> - Write down 3 inconsistencies. Are the fonts different? Is the pink on your page the same as the pink on your invoice? Is your logo stretched or pixelated?
>
> Don't fix anything yet. Just noticing them is the first step to closing the gap.

DAY 2 — DEFINE YOUR BRAND'S SOUL

On Day 1, you spotted your Trust Gap and the inconsistencies that may be costing you sales.

If you're like most sellers, your instinct right now is to open Canva, pick a new template and start moving things around.

Stop. Put the mouse down.

The biggest mistake entrepreneurs make is starting with visuals. Great design doesn't start with a sketch; it starts with a sentence.

If you don't know who your brand is, you can't dress it properly. It's like wearing a tuxedo to a beach party: it looks expensive, but it's completely wrong for the occasion.

Today, you'll define your brand's soul in about 20 minutes. It may sound abstract, but it's the most practical thing you'll do all week: it becomes the compass for every colour, font and photo you choose later. Without it, you're just picking pretty colours at random.

The party test

Imagine your brand is a person walking into a party.

- How do they introduce themselves?
- Are they the loud, funny one telling jokes in the middle of the room?
- The quiet, thoughtful observer having deep conversations in the corner?
- The rebel crashing the party in a leather jacket?

Design is just the outfit that person wears. But first, you need to decide on the personality.

Step 1: Pick your 3 core adjectives

To stay focused, pick just three words that describe how you want your brand to feel. Try to pick one from each category:

- **Emotional:** how does the customer feel? (For example: safe, excited, empowered.)
- **Descriptive:** what's the vibe? (For example: minimal, handcrafted, tech-savvy.)
- **Stylistic:** what's the tone? (For example: bold, quirky, elegant.)

A high-end perfume shop, for instance, might choose: valued, refined, elegant.

Step 2: The "anti-adjective"

This is a powerful trick for adding nuance: pick one word that your brand is NOT. It sets boundaries.

Examples:

- "We're fast, but not rushed."
- "We're premium, but not snobby."
- "We're fun, but not childish."

Step 3: The sanity check (archetypes)

Finally, align your brand with a classic character type, an **archetype**. It helps you stay consistent: if you know your brand is "the Rebel", you automatically know a delicate, flowery font isn't for you.

Common examples include:

- **The Creator:** innovative, artistic (often associated with Lego or Apple).
- **The Sage:** wise, expert, guiding (often associated with Google or Harvard).
- **The Caregiver:** nurturing, reassuring (often associated with Johnson & Johnson or WWF).

> **Your action for today: 20 minutes**
>
> Grab a sticky note or open a blank document right now. Write down:
>
> - your 3 core adjectives;
> - your anti-adjective;
> - your primary archetype.
>
> That's it. Keep this note visible. When you start picking colours, you'll ask yourself: "Does this neon green look like a wise Sage?" (The answer is probably no.)

DAY 3 — A MOOD BOARD THAT DOESN'T COPY YOUR COMPETITORS

On Day 2, you defined your brand's personality with three core adjectives and an archetype. You now know who your brand is.

Today, you figure out what it looks like.

But first, a warning.

At this stage, most people make a fatal mistake: they go to Pinterest or Google and search for their exact industry.

- A perfume shop searches "perfume branding".
- A cosmetics seller searches "cosmetics logo".
- A clothing brand searches "clothing store Instagram".

Please don't do this.

When you look to your direct competitors for inspiration, you enter an echo chamber. You end up using the same clichés as everyone else: the gold bottle on a black background for perfume, the green leaf for natural cosmetics, the clothes hanger for fashion. You blend in when the goal is to stand out.

Today, you'll build a mood board, but you'll do it the right way.

Step 1: Look "sideways" (not at your neighbours)

To create a unique visual identity, look at adjacent industries that share your adjectives, not your product.

Examples:

- **If your vibe is "calm, polished and premium"** (a cosmetics shop, for example): don't look at other cosmetics pages. Look at high-end Scandinavian spas, luxury hotels or handmade ceramics.
- **If your vibe is "rugged, durable and honest"** (leather accessories, for example): don't look at other leather goods shops. Look at vintage camping gear, workshop tools or artisan coffee packaging.

This is how you steal like an artist without cloning your competition.

Step 2: The treasure hunt (go offline)

Digital design can feel flat. Sometimes the best inspiration is in the physical world.

As you gather images today, look for:

- **Textures:** stone, paper, fabric, metal, ceramics.
- **Typography:** old book covers, restaurant menus, street signs.
- **Photography:** lighting styles (dark and moody, or bright and airy).
- **Architecture:** interior design often translates beautifully into layouts.

Step 3: The audience filter

Once you have a pile of images, you need to curate them. This is the hardest part.

You might personally love neon pink graffiti art. But if your ideal customer is looking for a refined perfume to give as a gift, that image, no matter how cool, has to go.

Design isn't about what you like. It's about what your customers trust.

> **Tip:** if you get stuck, go to a bookshop or a newsstand and look at magazine covers. Which ones would your ideal customer pick up? Snap a picture of those covers and add them to your board.

> **Your action for today: the 30-image diet**
>
> - Create a secret board on Pinterest or a folder on your computer.
> - Spend 15 minutes gathering 20 to 30 images based on your adjectives from Day 2. (Remember: look sideways!)
> - **The purge:** delete 5 images that are "cool" but don't fit your adjectives or your audience.
>
> By the end, you should have a collection of images that all feel like they belong to the same family. This board will be your North Star from now on.

DAY 4 — COLOURS AND FONTS: A SIMPLE SYSTEM

On Day 3, you built a mood board full of inspiration. You now have a "vibe".

Today, you turn that vibe into a system.

This is usually where people get stuck. They pick five lovely colours and three cool fonts, throw them all onto their page... and end up with a digital fruit salad.

Colour matters enormously: according to frequently cited research, a large share of snap judgements about a product may be based on colour alone. If your colours clash or "vibrate" on screen, you lose trust before anyone reads a single word.

You're going to simplify all this with two unbreakable rules used by interior designers and art directors.

Rule 1: The 60-30-10 framework

Stop trying to find a "perfect palette" of five equal colours. Instead, think of your brand colours like a well-tailored suit.

- **The neutral (60%):** this is your canvas. The background of your online shop, your visuals or your packaging. It creates space so your content can breathe. Examples: white, cream, charcoal, navy, soft beige.
- **The brand colour (30%):** this is your "suit", the main colour people associate with you. Use it for headlines, large blocks of text, bags or labels. It must match the adjectives you picked on Day 2. Examples: royal blue (trust), energetic orange (friendliness), forest green (calm).
- **The accent (10%):** this is the "tie" or the pocket square. Use it only for buttons, links and urgent notices ("Order now", "Sale", "Last items"). It should pop against the other two. Example: a bright yellow button on a blue background.

Rule 2: The typography "power couple"

Fonts carry emotional weight. A script font feels elegant; a blocky sans-serif feels modern and tech. Mixing them wrong is like wearing hiking boots with a tuxedo.

You only need two fonts:

- **The personality (headlines):** this font does the heavy lifting. It expresses your brand's soul and grabs attention.
- **The workhorse (body text):** this font has one job: readability. It should be plain, clean and easy to read at small sizes.

The golden rule: go for contrast. If your headline is thick and bold, make your body font thin and simple. If your headline is a fancy serif, keep the body font a clean sans-serif.

> **Do you also communicate in Arabic?** Choose fonts that come in an Arabic version, or pair a Latin font with an Arabic font of a similar style. Google Fonts lets you filter fonts by language (for example Cairo, Tajawal or Amiri for Arabic).

The final check: the squint test

Once you've picked your colours and fonts, mock up a simple visual: a headline, a sub-headline and a button (a banner for your shop or a product ad, for example).

Now step back from your screen and squint until the text blurs.

- Can you still tell what the most important element is? (It should be the headline.)
- Does the button stand out clearly? (It should be your 10% accent colour.)
- Is the text legible against the background? (This is crucial for accessibility.)

> **Tip:** if you're not sure your colours work together, search for "Color Contrast Checker" online. If your text fails the contrast test, your customers won't be able to read it.

> **Your action for today: draft your kit**
>
> Open a document and lock in your choices:
>
> - **Your 60-30-10:** one neutral, one brand colour and one accent.
> - **Your power couple:** go to Google Fonts and choose one headline font and one body font.
> - **The squint test:** put them together on a slide. Does it look professional or chaotic?
>
> That's it. You now have the raw materials of a professional brand.

DAY 5 — YOUR WORDMARK AND VISUAL STYLE

By now, you have your brand's soul (your adjectives), your inspiration (your mood board) and your raw materials (your colours and fonts).

Today, you build the thing everyone obsesses over: the logo.

But first, something difficult: lower your expectations.

When most people think "branding", they think of the Nike swoosh, the Apple apple or the McDonald's arches. So they spend weeks trying to draw a clever abstract icon that represents "synergy" or "growth".

Here's the hard truth: icons mean nothing until a brand spends a fortune on advertising to teach people what they stand for.

You don't have that fortune (yet). You need clarity, not mystery. You need a **wordmark**.

The power of the wordmark

A wordmark is simply your brand name, written in a specific font and treated as a logo. Think of Google, FedEx or Coca-Cola: no symbols, just text.

For the vast majority of small brands, a clean wordmark works better than a complex icon, because it tells customers exactly who you are, instantly.

Here's how to make yours with the fonts you picked on Day 4:

- **Type it out:** write your brand name in your headline font.
- **Play with hierarchy:** if your name has two words (for example "Lina Perfumes"), try "Lina" in bold and "Perfumes" in light. This creates visual interest.
- **Adjust the tracking:** "tracking" is designer-speak for letter spacing. In uppercase, add space: it looks premium. In lowercase, reduce it slightly: it looks friendlier.

> **Is your name in Arabic?** Don't space out Arabic letters: Arabic script is connected, and tracking breaks the joins between letters. Play with weight (bold or light) and size instead.

That's it. You don't need a graphic designer to draw a phoenix rising from the ashes. You just need clean typography.

The "Frankenstein" feed (photos and icons)

Your logo is done. Now let's talk about the rest of your visuals.

The fastest way to look like an amateur is a "Frankenstein" visual style, where every image looks like it came from a different planet.

1. Photography rules

Pick a lane and stick to it. Whether you shoot your own product photos or use free stock images (like Unsplash), filter them strictly:

- **Lighting:** dark, moody shadows, or bright, airy daylight? Pick one.
- **Temperature:** do your photos feel warm (yellows, oranges) or cool (blues, whites)?

Rule of thumb: if you put three of your photos side by side, they should look like they were taken by the same photographer on the same day.

2. Icon consistency

If you use icons (on your shop, your story highlights or your visuals), don't mix styles:

- Don't mix filled icons (solid shapes) with outlined icons (thin lines).
- Don't mix hand-drawn sketches with 3D renderings.

Pick one icon pack and stick to it religiously.

> **Tip:** when you export your logo, save one version in black and one in white. You'll need the white version for dark backgrounds.

> **Your action for today: the 15-minute logo**
>
> Today, your visual identity goes from idea to reality.
>
> - Open Canva (or your tool of choice).
> - Type your brand name in your chosen headline font.
> - Adjust the weight (bold or regular) and the tracking until it feels balanced.
> - Export it as a PNG with a transparent background. (In Canva, this option is part of the paid features; otherwise, use a free background-removal tool.)
>
> Congratulations: you've just saved yourself the cost of a generic, rushed logo.

DAY 6 — YOUR 5-PAGE BRAND BIBLE

You're almost at the finish line.

Over the last few days, you've defined your brand's soul, built a mood board, picked your colours and fonts, and created your logo.

You have all the ingredients of a strong brand. But right now, they're probably scattered across your desktop, your Downloads folder, your phone's gallery and three different Canva tabs.

That's a disaster waiting to happen.

Hunting for information already eats up a huge share of many professionals' working time. In branding, it looks like this:

- Searching for "that one hex code" yet again.
- Sending a blurry, pixelated logo to the printer for your labels or bags because you couldn't find the vector file.
- Posting something that looks slightly "off" because you guessed the font size.

Today, you'll build your **Brand Bible** (also known as a style guide). It's the document that keeps you consistent and saves your sanity.

The 5 essential pages

You don't need a 50-page technical manual. You just need a simple PDF you can send to your designer, your video editor, your printer or the freelancer who runs your ads. And, most importantly, something

you can check yourself when you're tired.

Here's exactly what goes on those pages.

Page 1 — The soul (strategy). List your 3 adjectives, your archetype and your mission statement. It reminds everyone why things are designed this way.

Page 2 — The logo (rules of engagement). Show your primary logo and your secondary versions. Crucially, include a "Don't do this" section:

- Don't stretch the logo.
- Don't rotate the logo.
- Don't place the logo on a busy background.

Page 3 — The colours (the codes). Show swatches of your 60-30-10 palette, and always include the codes:

- **HEX:** for screens (for example #FF5733).
- **RGB:** for digital documents.
- **CMYK:** for printing (paper requires different ink mixing!).

Page 4 — Typography (the hierarchy). List your headline font and body font, with their usage rules. For example: "Headlines are always bold and in sentence case. Body text is always light."

Page 5 — Imagery (the vibe). Add 3 to 5 photos from your mood board to show the "feel" of the brand. Add a note about icons (for example: "We only use thin, outlined icons").

Part 2: A future-proof file system

A Brand Bible is useless if you can't find the actual files. If your desktop looks like a digital graveyard full of "Logo_final_final_v3_REAL.png", it's time to fix that.

1. Know your formats

Stop guessing which file to use. Here's your cheat sheet:

- **JPG:** for photos only (no transparent backgrounds).
- **PNG:** for logos on the web (transparent backgrounds allowed).
- **SVG / EPS:** for print. These are "vector" files: you can scale them up to the size of a billboard and they won't get blurry.

2. Adopt a naming convention

Adopt this file-naming structure today, and future you will thank present you.

- **Format:** Brand_Element_Colour_Usage.ext
- **Example:** Lina_Logo_White_Print.eps

> **Tip:** if you ever hire a freelancer (a social media manager, an editor, a designer), send them your Brand Bible PDF and your assets folder from day one. They'll love you for it, and you'll both save hours of back-and-forth.

> **Your action for today: the one-hour clean-up**
>
> - **Create the Bible:** open Canva, make a 5-page presentation using the structure above and export it as a PDF.
> - **Create the folders:** one master folder called "BRAND ASSETS", with two sub-folders: "01_Digital" (RGB, PNGs for the web) and "02_Print" (CMYK, vector files for paper).
> - **Rename everything:** rename your new logos using the convention above. Delete the drafts.
>
> It feels tedious now. But the next time you need to prepare a campaign, print labels or launch a sales page, you'll feel like a real professional.

DAY 7 — STAY CONSISTENT OVER TIME

Congratulations! You've made it to Day 7.

This week, you've closed the Trust Gap, defined your brand's soul, built a mood board, picked your colours and fonts, created your logo and organised everything into a Brand Bible.

You've done the heavy lifting.

But there's one last warning, about the silent killer of great brands. It isn't bad design, and it isn't a lack of budget.

It's the **Boredom Paradox**.

Why you'll get tired of your own brand (and why that's good)

Here's what usually happens:

- **Month 1:** you love your new brand. It feels fresh and professional.
- **Month 3:** you've seen your logo thousands of times. You've used the same colour code every single day.
- **Month 6:** you start thinking: "Maybe we should shake things up? Maybe we need a rebrand?"

Please don't.

You're bored because you see your brand every single day. But your customers? They only see it once a week, or once a month.

In marketing, it's often said that a customer needs several interactions with a brand (5 to 7 is a commonly quoted figure) before they remember it. By the time you're bored to tears with your visual identity, your audience is only just starting to recognise it.

If you change your colours now, you reset the clock to zero. You lose all the trust you've built up.

The "hit song" mindset

Think of your brand like the biggest hit of a raï or chaâbi singer. They've sung it thousands of times and are probably a little tired of it. But the moment the first notes play, whether at a concert or a wedding party, the crowd goes wild.

Your job is to play the hits. Keep showing up with the same logo, the same fonts and the same colours. Consistency is the strategy.

How to evolve without destroying trust: the 10% rule

Does this mean you can never change anything? Of course not. But you should evolve, not reinvent.

Use the 10% rule: if you want to freshen things up, change 10% of your visual identity and keep the 90% that anchors your recognition.

- Don't change your logo; do try a new photography style for your summer collection.
- Don't swap your main colour; do introduce a temporary "pop" colour for an Eid promotion or a sale season.

> **Your action for today: the 5-point audit**
>
> To wrap up this guide, do a "consistency sweep". With your Brand Bible in front of you, look at these five places and ask: "Does this match the Bible?"
>
> - **Your social media bios:** is your profile picture the correct logo file?
> - **Your online shop header:** are the menu fonts your chosen body font?
> - **Your invoices and order forms:** does the PDF look like it comes from the same brand as your page?
> - **Your email signature and WhatsApp Business profile:** are you using random colours, or your brand colours?
> - **Your business cards, labels and packaging** (if you use them): is the logo stretched?
>
> Fix one of these today. It will take you 10 minutes, and your brand will look noticeably more professional.

CONCLUSION

Thank you for following these 7 days all the way through.

In one week, you've gone from an improvised look to a real system: a clear personality, a mood board, a palette and two fonts, a wordmark, a Brand Bible and well-organised files.

You now have everything you need to look like a pro, charge what you're worth and build a brand people trust.

Now it's your turn: make it memorable.

Hooked Academy — for enrolled students.